PIERCE COUNTY 4x4
SEARCH & RESCUE
Volunteer service • Pierce County, Washington

EMERGENCY
CALL 911

Emergency Signal Quick Reference

S.T.O.P., stay put, and signal clearly.

IF YOU'RE LOST: S.T.O.P.

S — SIT DOWN

Stop moving. Panic is your enemy. Every wrong step takes you farther from where rescuers will look.

T — THINK

When did you last know your location? Can you retrace your steps safely and confidently?

O — OBSERVE

Landmarks, trail markers, sounds of roads or water. Check your map and compass carefully.

P — PLAN

If unsure, STAY PUT. Make yourself visible and signal for help. We search your planned route first.

> **#1 RULE: STAY PUT**
>
> 80% of lost hikers are found within 1 mile of their last known position — when they don't wander. Moving makes it exponentially harder to find you.

AUDIO SIGNALS

- ☐ Whistle (BEST): 3 short blasts, pause, repeat. Heard up to 1 mile. Uses almost no energy. Always carry one.
- ☐ Voice: Shout 'HELP' in groups of 3. Cup hands, aim toward sounds. Save your voice — a whistle is 10x better.

VISUAL SIGNALS

- ☐ Signal mirror: Flash toward aircraft/ridgelines. Visible up to 10 miles on clear day. Any shiny surface works.
- ☐ Bright colors: Spread gear in open areas. Wave bright items overhead when you hear or see searchers.
- ☐ Fire / smoke: Fire visible at night; smoke during day. Add green branches for white smoke. 3 fires in triangle = SOS.
- ☐ Ground symbols: Make 10+ ft tall, high contrast to ground. X = need medical help. V = need assistance. SOS = distress.

ELECTRONIC + SATELLITE

- ☐ Cell phone: Try 911 even with no bars — connects via ANY carrier. Text 911 if voice call fails.
- ☐ Satellite 911 texting: FREE for all carriers via T-Mobile/ Starlink (emergency 911 only). Full messaging: $10/mo.
- ☐ iPhone 14+ SOS: Built-in satellite SOS, no subscription. Practice: Settings > Emergency SOS > Try Demo.
- ☐ Android SOS: Pixel 9+, Galaxy S25+ support satellite emergency messaging via phone settings.
- ☐ Garmin inReach: Two-way satellite texting + SOS with 24/7 monitoring center. ~$15/mo subscription.
- ☐ Battery saving: Airplane mode between 911 attempts. Reduce brightness. Texting uses less power than calls.

Scan a code or click a label to open the resource.

Satellite 911 Signup

Garmin inReach Mini 2